



TYPES OF CLAUSES

Main Clause

Noun Clause

Adjective Clause

Adverb Clause

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What is a Clause?

A clause is a group of words that has **BOTH** a subject and a verb.

Subject

Who or what the sentence is about

E.g.: The dog, She, My teacher

Verb

The action or state of being

E.g.: runs, is, wrote, helps

💡 Remember: A phrase has words but **NO** verb+subject pair. A clause always has **BOTH**!

Types of Clauses – Overview

1. Independent / Main Clause

Makes complete sense on its own.

2. Dependent / Subordinate Clause

Does not make complete sense on its own.

Types of Clauses – Overview

1. Independent / Main Clause

Makes complete sense on its own.

"She laughed."

2. Noun Clause

Acts like a noun in the sentence.

"What she said surprised me."

3. Adjective Clause

Describes a noun or pronoun.

"The boy who won is my friend."

4. Adverb Clause

Modifies a verb, adjective, or adverb.

"I left because I was tired."

Independent (Main) Clause

An independent clause can STAND ALONE as a complete sentence. It has a subject, a verb, and gives a complete thought.

Examples:

- The cat sat on the mat.
- Ravi plays cricket every evening.
- My mother cooks delicious food.
- They finished their homework.

Key Features

- ✓ Has a subject
- ✓ Has a verb
- ✓ Complete thought
- ✓ Can stand alone

! *A dependent clause CANNOT stand alone — it needs a main clause to make sense.*

Dependent Clauses

A dependent clause has a subject and verb BUT cannot stand alone — it depends on a main clause.

See the difference:

✓ **Independent**

"She smiled."

Complete sentence — makes sense alone.

✗ **Dependent**

"Because she smiled..."

Incomplete — we ask: what happened because she smiled?

Dependent clauses are of 3 types: Noun Clause | Adjective Clause | Adverb Clause

Noun Clause

A noun clause acts like a NOUN. It can be a subject, object, or complement in the sentence.

Common Starters:

that

what

who

whom

which

whether

how

why

when

where

Examples:

What he said was shocking.

I know **that she is right**.

Tell me **where you live**.

Adjective Clause

An adjective clause (also called a relative clause) DESCRIBES a noun or pronoun. It usually follows the noun it describes.

Relative Pronouns used:

who

whom

whose

which

that

Examples — the adjective clause is highlighted:

The girl **who won the prize** is my sister.

I met the man **whom you mentioned.**

The book **which is on the table** belongs to Raju.

This is the house **that Jack built.**

Adverb Clause

An adverb clause **MODIFIES** a verb, adjective, or another adverb. It tells us **WHEN, WHERE, WHY, HOW, or UNDER WHAT CONDITION**.

Types of Adverb Clauses:

Time Clause

*Keywords: **when, before, after, since, until***

I brush my teeth before I sleep.

Reason Clause

*Keywords: **because, since, as***

She stayed home because she was sick.

Condition Clause

*Keywords: **if, unless, provided that***

I will help you if you ask me.

Contrast Clause

*Keywords: **though, although, even though***

He passed although he didn't study.

Quick Comparison – All Clause Types

Clause Type	Acts as a...	Key Words	Example
Main / Independent	Complete sentence	—	She sang beautifully.
Noun Clause	Noun (subject/object)	what, that, who, whether	What she said was true.
Adjective Clause	Adjective (describes noun)	who, whom, whose, which, that	The cat that you saw is mine.
Adverb Clause	Adverb (modifies verb)	when, because, if, although	I left when it rained.

Tips to Identify Clauses

1

Find the VERB first

Every clause must have a verb. Underline all verbs in the sentence.

2

Find the SUBJECT

Ask 'Who or what is doing the action?' to find the subject.

3

Check for a CONNECTOR word

Words like because, who, what, when often start a dependent clause.

4

Ask: Does it make complete sense alone?

If YES → Independent clause. If NO → Dependent clause.

5

Decide the FUNCTION of the dependent clause

Does it act as a noun, adjective, or adverb in the sentence?

Let's Practice — Spot the Clause!

Q1. The dog that bit me ran away.

that bit me

Adjective Clause

Q2. She knows what you did.

what you did

Noun Clause

Q3. We stayed inside because it was raining.

because it was raining

Adverb Clause

Q4. Whoever finds the key will be rewarded.

Whoever finds the key

Noun Clause

1.



1. Identify the type of clause in bold:

"The woman **WHO LIVES NEXT DOOR** is a doctor."

A Noun Clause

B Adverb Clause

C Adjective Clause

D Independent Clause

Answer 1

1. Identify the type of clause in bold:

*"The woman **WHO LIVES NEXT DOOR** is a doctor."*

✓ CORRECT ANSWER: **C)** Adjective Clause

 Explanation:

"Who lives next door" describes the noun 'woman'. It acts like an adjective, so it is an Adjective (Relative) Clause.

2. Which of the following is an independent clause?

A Because he was late

B When the bell rings

C She finished her homework.

D What I told you

Answer 2

2. Which of the following is an independent clause?

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: C) She finished her homework.**

 **Explanation:**

"She finished her homework" has a subject (She), a verb (finished), and gives a complete thought. It can stand alone.

3.



3. "WHAT YOU EAT affects your health."
What type of clause is underlined?

A Adjective Clause

B Adverb Clause

C Noun Clause

D Main Clause

Answer 3

3. *WHAT YOU EAT affects your health.*
What type of clause is underlined?

✓ CORRECT ANSWER: C) Noun Clause

 Explanation:

"What you eat" is the subject of the sentence — it acts as a noun. Starting with 'what' and functioning as the subject, it is a Noun Clause.

4. Choose the sentence that contains an adverb clause.

A The cake that she baked was tasty.

B I know who broke the vase.

C He ran fast because he was scared.

D The boy who cried wolf came here.

Answer 4

4. Choose the sentence that contains an adverb clause.

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: C) He ran fast because he was scared.**

 **Explanation:**

"Because he was scared" tells us WHY he ran fast — it modifies the verb 'ran'. Beginning with 'because', it is an Adverb Clause of Reason.

5. "I will help you IF YOU NEED ME."

The highlighted clause is a/an:

A Noun Clause

B Adverb Clause of Condition

C Adjective Clause

D Independent Clause

Answer 5

5. *"I will help you IF YOU NEED ME."*
The highlighted clause is a/an:

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: B) Adverb Clause of Condition**

 **Explanation:**

"If you need me" expresses a condition under which help will be given. 'If' is a conditional subordinating conjunction, making this an Adverb Clause of Condition.

6. Which word typically begins a Noun Clause?

A

who (as relative pronoun in 'the man who...')

B

that (as in 'I think that...')

C

although

D

before

Answer 6

6. Which word typically begins a Noun Clause?

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: B) that** (as in 'I think that...')

 **Explanation:**

"That" can introduce a noun clause (e.g., 'I think that she is right'). 'Although' and 'before' introduce adverb clauses; 'who' in option A is used as a relative pronoun in an adjective clause.

**7. "THE BOY WHO CAME FIRST received a medal."
How many clauses are in this sentence?**

A One

B Two

C Three

D Four

Answer 7

**7. "THE BOY WHO CAME FIRST received a medal."
How many clauses are in this sentence?**

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: B) Two**

 **Explanation:**

Clause 1 (Main): 'The boy received a medal.' Clause 2 (Adjective): 'who came first'. Every clause must have its own subject + verb pair.

8. Choose the dependent clause from the options below.

A

The birds flew south.

B

She is a great singer.

C

Although it was raining

D

My father works hard.

Answer 8

8. Choose the dependent clause from the options below.

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: C) Although it was raining**

 **Explanation:**

"Although it was raining" cannot stand alone as a sentence — we wonder 'what happened although it was raining?' It depends on a main clause, so it is a dependent clause.

9. "WHEREVER YOU GO, I will follow."
Identify the underlined clause.

A Noun Clause

B Adjective Clause

C Adverb Clause of Place

D Independent Clause

Answer 9

9. ***"WHEREVER YOU GO, I will follow."***
Identify the underlined clause.

✓ **CORRECT ANSWER: C) Adverb Clause of Place**

 **Explanation:**

"Wherever you go" tells us WHERE I will follow. 'Wherever' is a subordinating conjunction of place, making this an Adverb Clause of Place.

10. "She told me **THAT SHE WOULD COME.**"

The bold part is a:

A Adjective Clause

B Adverb Clause

C Noun Clause

D Main Clause

Answer 10

10. "She told me **THAT SHE WOULD COME.**"

The bold part is a:

✓ CORRECT ANSWER: C) Noun Clause

📖 Explanation:

"That she would come" is the object of the verb 'told' — it answers 'what did she tell me?'
Acting as a noun (object), it is a Noun Clause.



What You've Learned!

✦ A clause has a subject + verb.

✓ An independent clause can stand alone as a sentence.

↔ Dependent clauses need a main clause to be complete.

? Noun clauses act as nouns (subject or object).

? Adjective clauses describe nouns (who, which, that).

● Adverb clauses modify verbs (when, because, if, although).